Typography

189 terms · name, then the phrase to paste · Workbook Library

Typefaces

Old-style serif an old-style serif like Garamond or Caslon: low stroke contrast, diagonal stress, warm and bookish

Transitional serif a transitional serif like Baskerville: moderate contrast, vertical stress, crisp bracketed serifs, authoritative and trustworthy

Didone a Didone serif like Bodoni or Didot: extreme thick-thin contrast, hairline serifs, vertical stress, used large for a glamorous fashion-magazine feel

Slab serif a slab serif like Rockwell or Clarendon: heavy rectangular serifs, low contrast, sturdy and mechanical

Inscriptional serif Roman inscriptional capitals like Trajan: all caps, wide stately proportions, chiseled serifs, ceremonial and epic

Soft serif a soft, rounded serif in the spirit of Cooper Black: heavy weight, blobby rounded serifs, warm and retro 1970s

Screen text serif a contemporary text serif made for screens, like Charter or Source Serif: large x-height, sturdy serifs, comfortable for long reading

Condensed editorial serif a condensed editorial display serif like Instrument Serif or Canela, set large and light with an italic for emphasis

Fat face a fat face poster serif like Ultra Bodoni: ultra-heavy verticals with hairline thins, loud and theatrical

Grotesque a grotesque sans like Franklin Gothic or Akzidenz-Grotesk: slightly irregular, a little stroke contrast, industrial and workmanlike

Neo-grotesque a neutral neo-grotesque sans like Helvetica or Inter: even strokes, closed apertures, clean and unopinionated

Geometric sans a geometric sans like Futura: near-perfect circles, pointed apexes, modernist and optimistic

Humanist sans a humanist sans like Frutiger or Source Sans: open apertures, subtle calligraphic stroke, warm and highly legible

Quirky grotesk a contemporary grotesk with quirky details, like Space Grotesk or Söhne: neutral structure, idiosyncratic letterforms, tech-studio feel

Rounded sans a rounded sans like VAG Rounded or Nunito: soft terminals, friendly and playful

Condensed sans a heavy condensed sans like Bebas Neue or Druk: tall narrow all-caps letters, tight spacing, urgent and loud

Extended sans a wide extended sans like Monument Extended: stretched horizontal proportions, heavy weight, bold and futuristic

Squared techno sans a squared techno sans like Eurostile or Microgramma: rounded-rectangle forms, flat sides, retro-futuristic sci-fi feel

Monospace a modern monospace like JetBrains Mono or IBM Plex Mono for code, data and small technical labels

Typewriter a typewriter face like Courier or American Typewriter, slightly uneven inked letters, like a typed document

Formal script a formal copperplate script like Snell Roundhand: pointed-pen hairlines and swells, elegant and ceremonial

Retro script a mid-century retro script like a 1950s diner sign or baseball jersey, connected and bouncy with a swash tail

Brush script an energetic brush script with fast, slanted strokes and rough edges, handmade and punchy

Handwriting a casual handwritten font like Caveat for notes and annotations, as if jotted with a pen

Blackletter a blackletter face like Fraktur or Old English: dense angular broken strokes, medieval and heavy

Tuscan woodtype Tuscan Western woodtype with forked, bulging serifs, like a 19th-century wanted poster or circus playbill

Display face one bold display face used only for the main title, paired with a plain text face for everything else

Stencil a stencil typeface with bridged gaps in the letters, like spray-painted shipping crates or military gear

Pixel / bitmap a pixel bitmap font like Press Start 2P, crisp square pixels, 8-bit arcade style

Variable font use a variable font and tune its axes (weight, width, optical size) instead of picking from fixed styles

Famous fonts

Garamond Garamond (EB Garamond as the free version) for an elegant, literary book feel

Baskerville Baskerville (Libre Baskerville as the free version), crisp and trustworthy, with its italic ampersand used as an accent

Bodoni and Didot Didot or Bodoni (Bodoni Moda as the free version) set large, like a Vogue cover

Times New Roman Times New Roman for a plain, official, newspaper-of-record feel

Georgia Georgia as a screen-friendly, universally installed body serif

Clarendon Clarendon-style bracketed slab serif (Roboto Slab Black as a free stand-in), hearty and Americana

Trajan Trajan-style Roman capitals (Cinzel as the free version), widely letter-spaced, like an epic movie poster

Cooper Black Cooper Black (Fraunces at its softest, heaviest setting as a free stand-in) for warm 1970s retro

Playfair Display Playfair Display for elegant high-contrast headlines, with its italic for emphasis

Helvetica Helvetica (Inter as the free version), tightly tracked in bold for a confident Swiss modernist voice

Futura Futura (Jost as the free version), geometric and confident, in bold caps

Gill Sans Gill Sans (or a humanist free alternative like Source Sans) for a classic British, slightly literary sans

Frutiger Frutiger-style humanist sans (Source Sans as a free stand-in), clear and friendly like airport signage

DIN DIN (Barlow as a free stand-in), engineered and technical, especially for numbers

Gotham Gotham (Montserrat as the free version), wide, confident all-caps sans

Franklin Gothic Franklin Gothic (Libre Franklin as the free version), heavy and newsy

Impact Impact-style meme text: ultra-heavy condensed white caps with a thick black outline, top and bottom of the image

Comic Sans Comic Sans (or Comic Neue), deliberately casual and goofy

Inter Inter for UI and body text, with Inter Display or tighter tracking for large headings, and tabular numbers in data

San Francisco (SF Pro) the system font (SF Pro via -apple-system / .body text styles) so it feels native on Apple platforms

Roboto Roboto (the Android/Material default) or the device system font on Android

IBM Plex the IBM Plex superfamily: Plex Sans for UI and text, Plex Mono for code and labels, Plex Serif for long reading

Verdana Verdana for a wide, highly legible early-web feel

System font stack the native system font stack (system-ui, -apple-system, Segoe UI, Roboto, sans-serif) so text loads instantly and feels native

Pairings

Serif headlines, sans body pair a characterful serif for headlines with a clean, neutral sans for body text and UI

Sans headlines, serif body bold, tightly tracked sans headlines over a comfortable serif for long body text

One superfamily one superfamily throughout (e.g. IBM Plex Sans, Serif and Mono) for variety that never clashes

One family, many weights a single type family for everything, with hierarchy from weight (800 / 600 / 400), size and color only

Mono accents small uppercase monospace labels for metadata, dates and tags alongside a clean sans for headings and text

Display face + workhorse one expressive display face only for the main title, everything else in a quiet neutral sans so the display face stands out

Script accent a script used for one or two accent words only, paired with widely tracked serif capitals for everything else

Contrast, not near-misses pair faces with clear contrast (different classification and weight) but similar x-height and proportions; never two near-identical faces

Fraunces + Inter Fraunces (soft, optical size up) for headlines with Inter for body and UI

Instrument Serif + Inter Instrument Serif at very large sizes (with italic accents) for headlines, Inter for everything else

Garamond + Futura Garamond (EB Garamond) for text and headlines, Futura (Jost) in spaced capitals for labels and navigation

Libre Baskerville + Libre Franklin Libre Baskerville for headlines and body, Libre Franklin bold for kickers, bylines and UI

Bodoni Moda + Work Sans Bodoni Moda for large headlines, Work Sans light in tracked capitals for navigation and captions

Bebas Neue + Inter Bebas Neue in big uppercase for headlines and numbers, Inter for body and UI

Oswald + Newsreader Oswald bold uppercase headlines with Newsreader for body text

Cinzel + EB Garamond Cinzel capitals for titles with EB Garamond for body text, epic and historical

Space Grotesk + JetBrains Mono Space Grotesk for headings and body, JetBrains Mono for code, labels and numbers

Syne + Inter Syne extra-bold for headlines, Inter for text, an experimental art-gallery feel

Rye + Courier Prime Rye Western woodtype for the title, Courier Prime for details, dusty frontier Americana

Shrikhand + Nunito Shrikhand for headlines and Nunito for text, cheerful retro friendliness

Hierarchy & setting

Modular type scale a modular type scale with a 1.25 ratio from a 16px base (13, 16, 20, 25, 31, 39, 49px), and only those sizes

Type roles define named type roles (display, headline, title, body, label, caption), each with a fixed size, weight, line height and tracking, and use only those

Eyebrow a small uppercase, letter-spaced eyebrow label in the accent color above each section headline

Deck under each headline, a one-to-two sentence deck set about 1.3× body size in a lighter color

Dramatic scale contrast dramatic scale contrast: one very large headline (8–10× body size) and small body text, no middle sizes

Hierarchy without size in dense UI, keep text within 2–3 sizes and create hierarchy with weight and three text colors (primary, secondary, tertiary)

Big number key figures set as big numbers (display size, tight tracking, tabular figures) with a small label underneath

Metadata line a single small, muted metadata line (author · date · read time) separated by middle dots, placed tight under the title

Line length body text limited to about 65 characters per line (max-width: 65ch), even on wide screens

Line height line height 1.5–1.6 for body text, 1.05–1.15 for large headlines

Letter-spacing tighten large headings (about -0.02em to -0.04em), loosen small uppercase labels (+0.08em to +0.15em), leave body text at 0

Ragged vs. justified flush-left, ragged-right body text; only justify with hyphenation turned on (hyphens: auto)

Balanced headlines balanced line breaks on headings (text-wrap: balance) so multi-line headlines have even lines

No widows or orphans avoid single-word last lines in paragraphs (text-wrap: pretty or a non-breaking space) and never leave a heading at the bottom of a column

Vertical rhythm a consistent vertical rhythm: line heights and margins all multiples of an 8px base unit

Fluid type fluid type for headings with CSS clamp() (e.g. clamp(2rem, 5vw + 1rem, 4.5rem)) so they scale smoothly from phone to desktop

Paragraph spacing or indents separate paragraphs with a first-line indent of 1.5em and no extra space, like a printed book

Drop cap open the article with a three-line drop cap in the display serif (CSS initial-letter: 3)

Pull quote pull quotes set large in the italic display serif, with an oversized opening quotation mark and thin rules above and below

Small-caps lead-in start each section with its first three to five words in letter-spaced small caps

Hanging punctuation hang opening quotation marks and bullets outside the text block so the letters align with the left edge

Sidenotes sidenotes in the right margin aligned with their reference (Tufte style), collapsing to tap-to-expand notes on phones

Captions & credits image captions in a small sans, with a short bold lead-in and the credit in small caps or a lighter color

Running heads & folios running heads with the chapter title in small spaced caps at the top of each page, and folios (page numbers) at the outer bottom corner

Section break mark section breaks with a centered dinkus (three spaced asterisks) instead of a heading

Readable body size body text at least 16px (18–20px for long reading), nothing under 12px, and form inputs at 16px or more so mobile Safari doesn't zoom

Text contrast all text meets WCAG AA contrast (4.5:1 for body, 3:1 for large text), including placeholder and secondary text

Caps and italics in small doses use all caps only for short labels (with added letter-spacing) and italics only for emphasis and titles, never for whole paragraphs

Respect text size settings support user text scaling (rem on web, Dynamic Type on iOS, sp on Android) and make sure layouts reflow up to 200% text size

Legibility-first fonts a legibility-first font like Atkinson Hyperlegible, with clearly distinct I/l/1 and O/0 shapes

Fast font loading load at most two font families as variable WOFF2 files, preload the body font, use font-display: swap, and size-adjust the fallback font to avoid layout shift

Free vs. licensed fonts use only free, open-licensed fonts (Google Fonts or Fontshare), and name the closest free alternative for any commercial typeface

Details & OpenType

Baseline, x-height, cap height a typeface with a generous x-height and short descenders so it stays readable at small sizes

Large vs. small x-height choose a typeface with a large x-height for UI and small sizes

Stroke contrast high stroke contrast with hairline thins, only at display sizes

Serif shapes a serif with soft bracketed serifs (or: hairline / slab / wedge serifs)

Open vs. closed apertures a sans with open apertures for legibility at small sizes and at a distance

Terminals a serif with ball terminals on a, c, f, r and y for a lively classical feel

True italic vs. oblique a typeface with a true cursive italic for emphasis, not a slanted roman

Weight range headlines at weight 800, subheads at 600, body at 400, captions at 400 in a lighter color

Width the condensed width of the family for headlines so long titles fit on one line

Optical size use optical sizes: the display cut for headlines and the text cut for body (font-optical-sizing: auto with a variable font)

Tabular figures tabular figures (font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums) for every table, price, timer and changing number

Old-style figures old-style figures in running text (oldstyle-nums), lining figures in tables and headings

True small caps true small caps (font-variant-caps: all-small-caps) for acronyms like NASA and HTML in running text

Ligatures standard ligatures on for body text; discretionary ligatures (ct, st) only in the display title for an antique touch

Fractions & superscripts true diagonal fractions (diagonal-fractions) in recipes and measurements, and real superscripts for footnotes and ordinals

Slashed zero & clear glyphs slashed zeros (slashed-zero) and clearly distinct I/l/1 in codes, API keys and reference numbers

Stylistic alternates enable the font's stylistic alternates (e.g. single-story a and g) for a friendlier, more geometric look

Kerning kerning on everywhere, and hand-check letter pairs in the logo and largest headlines

Refined underlines link underlines with text-underline-offset: 0.2em, 1px thickness in a muted color, thickening on hover, and skip-ink on

Treatments

Oversized hero type an oversized hero headline that spans the full viewport width (font-size around 12–18vw), tight tracking and leading, no hero image

Stacked headline a stacked headline: one or two words per line in heavy condensed uppercase, line height about 0.85 so lines nearly touch

Italic serif accent a sans-serif headline with one key word set in an italic serif (like Instrument Serif Italic) for emphasis

Outlined type alternate solid and outlined lines in the headline (outlined using -webkit-text-stroke, transparent fill)

Image-filled type a short, ultra-bold headline filled with a photo through the letterforms (background-clip: text)

Gradient text one key phrase in the headline filled with a two- or three-color gradient (background-clip: text); the rest solid

Highlighter marks emphasize one word in the headline with a hand-drawn marker highlight or a loose underline swash behind it

Strikethrough correction a headline that strikes through one word and replaces it with another, as a visible edit

Vertical type a short vertical label running up the left edge (writing-mode: vertical-rl, rotated 180°), in small tracked caps

Text on a path a circular badge with the name set around the edge on a circle path (SVG textPath) and a small mark in the center

Type over image a magazine-cover layout where the masthead sits partly behind the subject, giving depth

Wide-tracked capitals the wordmark and navigation in widely letter-spaced capitals (letter-spacing about 0.3em), light weight

Cropped giant letters one or two giant letters cropped off the edges of the frame as a graphic backdrop behind smaller text

Forced-justified block a headline block where each line is sized to fill the same width exactly, forming a solid rectangle

Repeated echo the title repeated five times in a column, the center line solid and the others fading out or outlined

3D extruded chunky 3D extruded letters with a solid darker-color extrusion down and to the right (stacked text-shadows)

Offset shadow a hard offset shadow behind the headline: a flat second-color copy shifted down and right, no blur

Neon glow neon glow text: a near-white core with layered pink and magenta glows on a near-black background, a subtle flicker

Chrome / metallic chrome metallic lettering: a mirror gradient from pale sky blue to a sharp horizon line to dark brown, with a thin bright outline and a lens-flare highlight

Glitch / RGB split a glitch effect on the title: offset red and cyan copies (RGB split) with occasional horizontal slice jitter

Letterpress / debossed debossed letterpress text pressed into thick cotton paper: a soft inner shadow above and a light highlight below

Distressed texture distressed, worn-ink texture on the display type, with speckled gaps and rough edges like an old print

Marquee ticker an infinite horizontal marquee of large uppercase text separated by ✦ marks, scrolling slowly, paused for reduced-motion users

Typewriter reveal the hero line types itself out character by character with a blinking block cursor, once, then rests

Variable weight motion animate the headline's variable weight axis from thin to black on hover (or with scroll), smoothly, using a variable font

Staggered reveal headline lines slide up from behind a mask one after another (80ms stagger, ease-out), once on load

Rotating word one word in the headline cycles through three alternatives every 2.5 seconds with a vertical slide

Styles & eras

Victorian playbill a Victorian woodtype playbill: centered lines mixing many typefaces (Tuscan, fat face, slab, condensed gothic) at different sizes, ornamental rules and stars, on aged cream paper

Art Deco Art Deco typography: tall thin geometric capitals, wide tracking, gold on black, symmetrical layout with sunburst and stepped ornaments

Bauhaus Bauhaus typography: geometric lowercase sans, primary red, yellow and blue with black, circles and bars on an asymmetric grid

Constructivism Constructivist typography: heavy condensed sans on sharp diagonals, red and black on cream, thick bars and dynamic angles

Swiss / International Style Swiss International Style: a neo-grotesque like Helvetica, flush-left ragged-right on a strict modular grid, asymmetric layout, generous white space, black and white with one red accent

60s psychedelic 1960s psychedelic poster lettering: swelling, warped letterforms filling the space, vibrating complementary colors like orange on purple

70s groovy 1970s groovy typography: soft heavy Cooper Black-style serifs, orange-mustard-brown palette, rounded rainbow stripes

80s synthwave 80s synthwave typography: chrome italic headline with a neon script subtitle, over a striped magenta-orange sunset and a glowing perspective grid

90s grunge 90s grunge typography in the style of David Carson: distressed typewriter and mismatched faces, overlapping and rotated words, deliberately broken legibility

Y2K Y2K typography: wide extended sans with iridescent chrome fill, sparkle stars, small pixel-font captions, pastel holographic background

Web brutalism brutalist web typography: Times New Roman and monospace at clashing sizes, raw black borders, default blue underlined links, no rounded corners or shadows

Punk zine / ransom note punk zine ransom-note lettering: each letter cut from a different magazine and pasted crookedly, black and white photocopy grain, tape and marker scrawl

Luxury fashion editorial luxury fashion editorial typography: a very large high-contrast Didone headline, tiny widely tracked sans captions, extreme white space

Newspaper broadsheet old newspaper front-page typography: blackletter masthead, thin and thick rules, narrow justified serif columns, condensed bold headlines and a dateline

Western frontier Western frontier typography: Tuscan woodtype headline, slab serif and typewriter details, sepia aged paper, stars and a rope border

Modern tech minimal modern tech-minimal typography: one neutral sans (Inter or Geist), tight negative tracking on headings, generous white space, small mono labels, one accent color

Japanese poster Japanese poster typography: large vertical Japanese headline set top to bottom, small horizontal Latin captions, a flat color field and precise grid

Lettering & images

Hand-painted sign hand-painted gold-leaf sign lettering on a shop window: a script word over block capitals, black outline and drop shadow, slight brush imperfection

Hand lettering a hand-lettered composition: the phrase drawn as one interlocking unit mixing bouncy script and tall caps, with small flourishes and banners

Calligraphy pointed-pen copperplate calligraphy in black ink on textured cotton paper, with hairline flourishes and swelling downstrokes

Brush lettering expressive dry-brush lettering in black ink, fast slanted strokes with frayed bristle texture at the ends

Chalkboard chalkboard lettering: dusty white and pastel chalk on a dark green-black slate, mixed hand-drawn styles with simple borders and doodles

Neon sign a real neon sign: glowing pink and blue glass tubes bent into script lettering, mounted on a dark brick wall, soft light spill and one flickering letter

Screen-printed poster a screen-printed gig poster: two flat ink colors (rust and navy) slightly misregistered with multiply overprint, paper grain, bold condensed type

Marquee lights marquee bulb lettering: large letters outlined with rows of warm glowing light bulbs, against a dark night sky

Carved inscription Roman capitals carved into pale limestone with V-cut grooves, raking side light, weathered surface

Embroidered patch an embroidered patch with satin-stitched lettering and a thick merrowed border, visible thread texture, on canvas

Rubber stamp a red rubber-stamp mark at a slight angle: bold condensed caps inside a double border, uneven ink and worn gaps

Split-flap board split-flap departure board lettering: white uppercase characters on individual black flap tiles with a center seam, yellow headings

Typewritten page a typewritten page on aged paper: uneven ribbon ink, slightly jumping letters, a few x-ed out words and pencil corrections

Quote the exact words the poster reads "TALL PINES" in large letters and "LIVE AT THE GRANGE" underneath, spelled exactly as written

Keep it to a few words only short text in the image: the title (one to four words) and nothing else; no paragraphs or small print

Describe the look, not the font lettering described by its look: tall condensed sans-serif capitals, off-white, slightly distressed, tightly spaced

Text as part of the scene the words "NIGHT RIVER" painted in faded white capitals on the side of a weathered red barn, lit by a low evening sun

Say where the text goes the title large and centered across the top third, the subtitle small along the bottom edge, nothing covering the subject's face

Leave room for type no text in the image; leave a clean, uncluttered area of open sky in the top third for a title to be added later

Cover title block a cover title lockup: the artist name in small tracked capitals above the album title in a large italic serif, locked together, bottom left